CASE STUDY · PAYSCALE · 2024–2025

Live Certification Week: bringing a self-paced academy to life

I conceived and led a live, multi-day certification event that turned a self-paced video academy into an instructor-led experience. Both years it ran, it produced the highest monthly certification count of the year.

204%

increase in monthly certifications over the prior month at launch (2024)

113%

increase in monthly certifications over the prior month the following year (2025)

Top month

for certifications in both 2024 and 2025, with live attendance well above industry benchmarks

The challenge

Our newly launched Academy certification program was built on short-form videos and articles. That suits independent, self-paced learners, but not everyone learns that way.

Many learners absorb material better in a live setting, where they can ask questions in the moment and work through content on a defined schedule. Without that structure, they were less likely to start or finish a certification. We needed a way to reach them and build momentum behind the new program, without rebuilding the curriculum from scratch.

The approach

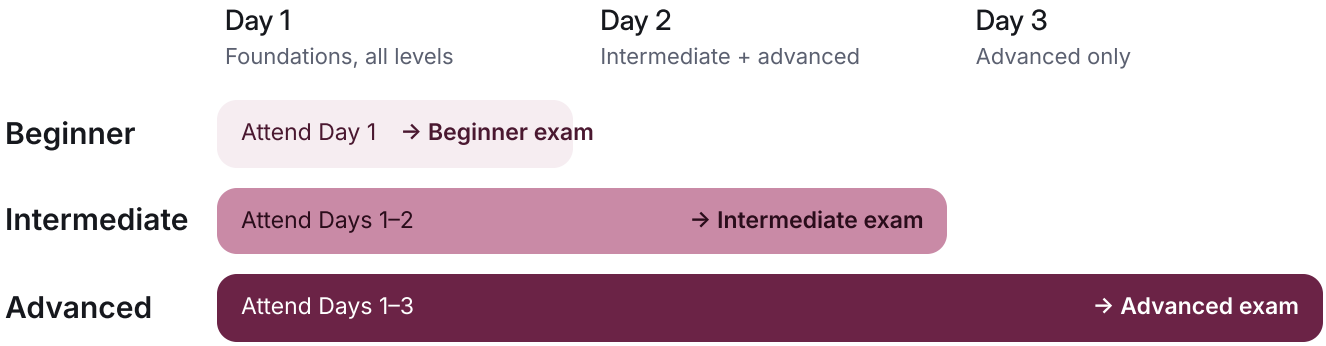
I proposed a live certification event to complement the video series. Instead of writing new curriculum, we translated the existing video scripts into webinar scripts and delivered them over several days in 90–120 minute sessions.

The first year covered two certifications: Compensation Fundamentals and one of our flagship products, whose video scripts I had also written.

A tiered format that builds day by day

Each learner attends only as far as their goal requires

The flagship product course already had beginner, intermediate and advanced tiers. I mirrored that structure across three days, with each day building on the one before. Exam links went out at the end of the matching day, so learners could certify while the material was fresh.



Built-in engagement

Knowledge checks

Regular sample questions drawn from the exam kept the audience active and surfaced confusing topics, which we clarified live through chat and Q&A.

Built-in engagement

Attendee-only study guides

I created guides covering key points and topics, built from the webinar transcripts, as an exclusive incentive to attend live.

Execution

Working within the tools we had, then scaling once the model was proven.

2024 · Zoom

Working around platform limits

Zoom couldn't handle registration for a multi-day, multi-level event. I built a simple Asana intake form that asked which certification level each registrant wanted, then imported registrations into the right webinar days so everyone got invites for exactly the sessions they needed.

2025 · Goldcast

Scaling with the right tools

We moved to Goldcast, which supports multi-day events and sessions natively. Learners chose their own sessions and the manual registration work went away. We kept all existing content and added certifications for two more products using the same tiered method.

Compensation Fundamentals

Enabling subject matter experts

I sourced SMEs from across the organization to lead specific topics, coached them on training techniques and audience engagement, and gave design-centered feedback on their supporting content and deliverables.

Promotion

Reaching learners in three places

- **In product:** Pendo announcements surfaced the event while users were working
- **In the inbox:** featured placement in our monthly webinar email digest
- **Through accounts:** CSMs promoted the event directly to their customers

My role

I owned Live Certification Week from idea to delivery.

Concept
Identified the gap for live learners and proposed the event

Program design
Created the tiered, multi-day structure for content across levels

Content
Wrote the flagship product video scripts and led their adaptation into webinar scripts

Presenters
Decided which presenters would lead each topic

Slide design
Designed or co-designed the accompanying slide decks

Registration
Devised the Asana intake workaround for Zoom's limitations

Study guides
Proposed and built attendee-only guides from webinar transcripts

SME coaching
Sourced and coached presenters on delivery, engagement and content design

Results

In both 2024 and 2025, the event month was our highest certification month of the year.

2024 · Launch year

+204%

monthly certifications over the prior month

Compensation Fundamentals + flagship product

2025 · Second year

+113%

monthly certifications over the prior month

Compensation Fundamentals + 3 products

Attendance

In 2025, the share of registrants who attended live came in well above the industry benchmark of roughly 40%.

Engagement

Academy student activity spiked during the 2025 event week.

Key takeaways

Meet learners where they are.

Adding a live option to self-paced content reached a different audience and multiplied certifications.

Reuse before you rebuild.

Adapting existing video scripts delivered a new format without new curriculum.

Let structure do the work.

A tiered, cumulative schedule let each learner commit only the time their goal required.

Solve for today's tools, then scale.

A simple Asana workaround launched the event on Zoom; Goldcast removed the manual work once it was proven.

Build a repeatable model.

The same method extended to two more product certifications in year two.

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